

Φιλίτας ὁ Κῶος

Philetas of Cos on Demeter, Grammar, and the Elegiac Tradition

eul_aid: hvm

Period: Ἑλληνιστική [Hellenistic](#)

Dialect: Ἀττική [Attic](#)

Domain: Ποίησις [Poetry](#)

Format: Ἑμμετρος [Verse](#)

Philetas of Cos was a Hellenistic poet and scholar active around 300 BCE. Born on the island of Cos, he served as tutor to Ptolemy II Philadelphus and taught the poet Hermesianax and the grammarian Zenodotus of Ephesus. He was renowned for both his poetry and his philological scholarship, with later writers humorously noting his meticulous, fragile nature as a scholar.

Major surviving works, known only from fragments, include the elegiac poem **Demeter**, the hexameter poem **Hermes**, and the epigrams **Paegnia**. His prose glossary **Ataktoi Glossai**, explaining rare words, is now lost.

Philetas is a foundational figure in Alexandrian literature, highly esteemed by later poets including Callimachus, Theocritus, Propertius, and Ovid. His refined, allusive poetry helped establish Hellenistic aesthetic ideals, and his dual role exemplifies the scholarly-poetic synthesis of the period.

Works (4)

- Ἀποσπάσματα Καρτερίας καὶ Μοίρας · [Fragments of Endurance and Fate](#) · 44 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Δήμητρος καὶ Τόπων · [Fragments on Demeter and Places](#) · 6 passages
- Γραμματικά Ἀποσπάσματα · [Grammatical Fragments](#) · 107 passages
- Ποιητικά Ἀποσπάσματα · [Poetic Fragments](#) · 46 passages